

Modal Perfect: Should Have, Must Have, Might Have

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Talk about the past with regret, certainty, or uncertainty.

You already use must/might/should for the present and future. Add "have + past participle" and they move into the past — for regret, deduction, and uncertain guesses about what happened.

Rules

a) Should have / shouldn't have — regret, criticism

- You should have called me. (you didn't, and that was a mistake)
- I shouldn't have eaten so much. (I did, and I regret it)

b) Must have — confident deduction

- He must have left already — his car is gone. (strong evidence, confident guess)

c) Might have / could have — uncertain guess

- She might have missed the bus. (just a possibility, not certain)
- They could have forgotten about the meeting.

Examples

- You should have told me earlier.
- I shouldn't have said that.
- He must have forgotten his phone — it's still on the table.
- She might have missed the bus.
- They could have gotten lost.
- We should have left earlier to avoid the traffic.

Common Mistakes

✗ You should have call me.

✓ You should have called me.

The modal perfect needs the past participle (called), not the base form.

✗ He must has left already.

✓ He must have left already.

Modal verbs never change form — always "have," never "has," regardless of subject.

✗ She might had missed the bus.

✓ She might have missed the bus.

The correct form is "might have," not "might had."

✗ I should have not said that.

✓ I shouldn't have said that.

The negative goes as "shouldn't have," not "should have not."

Summary

- Should have/shouldn't have = regret or criticism about the past.
- Must have = a confident deduction, based on evidence.
- Might have/could have = an uncertain guess about the past.
- Always: modal + have + past participle — never "has," never the base or past tense form of the main verb.

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